

(B) Jehovah's Witnesses

BRIEF INTRODUCTION

Jehovah's Witnesses (officially 'The Watch Tower Bible and Tract Society'), considered a Christian cult (not a branch or denomination) by majority of the Christians, with approximately 8 million (2015 estimates) active members (often called Witnesses) and about 19 million adherents (including potential members) altogether worldwide. The movement is founded (promoted/restored/revived) by a group of Bible students under the leadership of Charles Taze Russell (1852-1916) towards the end of the 19th century (in late 1870s) in the USA.

Jehovah is the personal name of God found in the Bible and witness is a person who proclaims views or truths of which he is convinced; hence the name Jehovah's Witnesses means Christians who proclaim the truth about God. Charles Taze Russell and a group of Bible students formed a Bible study group in 1870 (or 1872) CE. Russell and his group was convinced that Jesus Christ had returned to earth invisibly in 1874 (an idea held by Christian Millerite remnant).

Russell and his group published (promoting ideas and beliefs from their bible study) its first magazine "Zion's Watch Tower and Herald of Christ's Presence" in 1879 CE in Pennsylvania. Supporters of the movement grew steadily and in 1884 CE 'Zion's Watch Tower Tract Society' was officially incorporated, with Russell as its president. After his death (1916 CE) Joseph F. Rutherford became the second president and established the movement in firm footing. During his tenure the movement adopted (in 1931 CE) the title "Jehovah's Witnesses".

Jehovah's Witnesses see themselves as pioneers of promoting the true teachings of Jesus Christ according to the Bible and following the practices of the first-century Christian congregation. The movement grew within USA and internationally through its focus on missionary activity, as all active members are involved (door to door preaching) to proclaim the faith to others. Jehovah's Witnesses who are active proclaimers of the good news of the Kingdom are also known as publishers. The headquarter of the Jehovah's Witnesses is located in New York, USA. Today vast majority (almost one-third) of Mormons live in United States and Mexico; and the rest are found mostly in Brazil, Congo, Zambia, Nigeria, Philippines, Colombia and Angola.

Jehovah's Witnesses are distinct from all other mainstream Christian denominations in many of its beliefs and practices; and is thus considered by majority of the Christians as a cult in oppose to a branch or denomination.

PURPOSE OF LIFE

The purpose of life is to earn the right to live forever in God's future Kingdom on earth (and in Heaven for some), called Earthly Paradise and to help others to do so.

CONCEPT OF GOD

Jehovah's witnesses reject the mainstream Christian view of trinity or Trinitarian god. They also deny the deity of Christ and Holy Spirit. These differences put them in odds with the mainstream Christians.

God: They believe there is only one true and Almighty God, the Creator, whose personal name is Jehovah. Jehovah is alone, above all other beings and all worship should be directed toward Him. God is an invisible spirit person who had no beginning or end.

Jesus Christ: Jehovah's Witnesses unlike mainstream Christianity do not believe Jesus to be God or equal to God or worthy of worship. They believe he was God's first creation and "only-begotten Son" meaning he was the only one directly created by God. Jesus was a spirit creature in heaven before he was born as a human on earth. Jesus lived alongside Jehovah in heaven longer than any other spirit creature. Jehovah created everything else through Jesus.

~~Jesus is also called "the Word" because he tells everyone (both spirit and human) that he spoke for God, delivering messages and instructions from God.

~~Jesus was born as a perfect human to virgin Mary. He taught people the truth about God, lived a perfect exemplary life for people to follow and sacrificed his life to set people free from sin and death. He was crucified on a upright stake not on a cross. On third day God resurrected him back to spirit life and he returned to heaven. Jesus then waited at God's right hand until Jehovah gave him power to rule as King over all the earth. Now (since 1914) Jesus is ruling as King in heaven, and his followers are announcing that good news worldwide.

~~They follow the teachings and example of Jesus Christ and honor him as their Savior.

The Holy Spirit: Jehovah's Witnesses unlike mainstream Christianity do not believe holy spirit being a separate entity, a spirit person, and God or part of Godhead. They believe the holy spirit is Jehovah's power in action, his active force. Jehovah sends out His spirit by projecting His energy to any place to accomplish His will.

SOURCES OF RELIGIOUS/SACRED INFORMATION

Jehovah's Witnesses (like the Protestant denominations) only considers the holy Bible as the source of religious/sacred information. They have their own version of the Bible called 'The New World Translation of the Holy Scriptures'; although almost identical to most widely used protestant Bible, few key passages, such as those about the nature of Jesus, contains slightly different information.

KEY FEATURES OF BELIEF

THE CHURCH AND ORGANIZATION

Jehovah's Witnesses organization is hierarchical, headquartered in Warwick, New York and currently led by the Governing Body, a small group of mature male Christians(experienced elders). They are anointed brothers who are of God's 'faithful and discreet slave' class. They along with six

committees provide both ecclesiastical and administrative leadership for Jehovah's Witnesses worldwide.

~~Locally congregations are led by a body of 'elders', who are men chosen and appointed by the Governing Body upon recommendation from local congregations.

~~The house of worship is called a kingdom hall (in oppose to church). Kingdoms halls are modest in design and devoid of images, statues and altars (which they consider idolatry).

THE CLERGY

Jehovah's Witnesses do not have paid professional clergy. There is no distinction between clergy and lay people as all baptized members are considered ordained ministers. Members who led the local congregation are called elders and those who assist the elders are called ministerial servants. All baptized members share in the preaching and teaching work. Although woman do not teach or preach in congregation of mixed (male and female) gathering.

~~All active male and female members carry out ministerial work of preaching and declaring the good news of the kingdom of God from door to door in their communities and in other areas. Active members known as publishers are usually required to do at least one hour of ministerial service per month.

~~Jehovah's Witnesses also do not allow woman or homosexuals to be part of congregational or higher leadership position.

MARY

Jehovah's Witnesses believe Mary was a virgin chosen by God to be the mother Jesus and she had other children afterwards with her husband Joseph. They reject the Roman Catholic traditions of Mary mother of God, the immaculate Conception, the perpetual virginity and assumption of Mary. They also do not worship or use her for intercessory prayer.

THE SAINTS

Jehovah's Witnesses do not have a special category of beings who are called saints, who they pray to or ask for intercession.

THE ANGELS

Jehovah's Witnesses believe angels (similar to Protestantism) are powerful spirit creatures, created by God long before the creation of mankind. Angels have different ranks and are assigned a variety of functions by God.

ANOINTED BROTHERS AND SISTERS

Anointed brothers and sisters are also known as the "little flock". Becoming anointed is not something done by election or selection, rather one knows directly from God that he or she has been chosen as anointed. The vast majority of Jehovah's Witnesses are not anointed and will not spend eternity in heaven. The anointed person usually do not tell everyone that he is anointed or boast about the wonderful things he will do in heaven. The number of anointed are a total of 144,000 persons.

The Faithful and discreet slave is made up of a small group of anointed brothers who directly prepare and give out spiritual food to brothers around the world (throughout the last days); and bear the responsibility to manage everything on earth that belongs to Christ.

Jesus and Jehovah came and inspected all the Christians groups from 1914 to 1919 CE and were pleased with a small group of loyal Bible Students who showed that they truly loved Jehovah and his Word. After a period of testing, cleansing and refining, Jesus in 1919 CE selected qualified anointed brothers from them to be 'the faithful and discreet slave' and appointed them over his domestics (all the Jehovah's Witnesses). Today these anointed brothers make up the Governing body of Jehovah's Witnesses.

THE FALLEN ANGELS (SATAN AND DEMONS)

There is no major difference between Jehovah's Witnesses and mainstream Christian belief about fallen angels (Satan and demons).

CEREMONIES (RITES)

Jehovah's Witnesses observe two principle ceremonies (or rites); Baptism and Lord's Evening Meal. They do not consider these ceremonies as sacraments, or religious practices that imparts merit such as grace or the forgiveness of sins.

Baptism: Jehovah's Witnesses baptism is for those individuals who are old enough to understand and believe in "the good news of the Kingdom of God". Baptism is done by full water immersion after hearing God's word, accepting it, and repenting. Water baptism symbolizes an individual's dying to his past course of life, beginning a new life in harmony with Jesus' teachings and dedicated to God.

Lord's Evening Meal (the Memorial): The purpose of the Lord's Evening Meal (or Lord's Supper) or 'the Memorial' is to remember Jesus, showing their gratitude for his sacrifice in their behalf. It is a literal meal consisting of unleavened bread and simple wine (not juice or water) as symbols of Christ's body and blood; a memorial of Jesus' death. They observe this once a year (not once a week like most Christians) after sundown on Nisan 14. When Jehovah's Witnesses observe the Lord's Evening Meal, only a small fraction 'those who have been called in a special way by God' (the anointed ones) partake of the bread and wine.

WORSHIP AND PRAYER

All worship and prayer directed to God alone. Worship includes prayer, reading/studying Bible, meditating on lessons from the Bible, Constructing and maintaining Kingdom Halls, preaching and expressing the "good news of the Kingdom" etc. Jehovah's Witnesses do not Fast.

~~Jehovah's Witnesses are expected to participate regularly in congregational meetings, evangelizing work and attending conventions

~~Jehovah's Witnesses hold meetings for worship twice a week (Weekend meeting on Sunday and midweek meeting in the evening), held in local kingdom hall and are open to public. At these meetings they study and discuss Bible and 'Watch Tower Society' (Jehovah's witnesses publication) produced materials. These meetings begin and end with song and prayer.

~~Jehovah's Witnesses do not celebrate any popular mainstream Christian religious holidays such as Christmas and Easter.

~~Jehovah's Witnesses do not practice tithing (giving one-tenth of income) but encourage anonymous voluntary donations.

SIN

Sin is any action, feeling or thought that goes against God's commandments. It includes doing what is wrong or unrighteous, or failing to do what right, in God's sight.

~~Forgiveness for sin is through acknowledging, confessing to God, feeling sorrow, turn around, restitution as much as possible, and asking God for forgiveness on the basis of the ransom of Jesus.

~~For serious sins one need to speak to someone who is qualified to provide the spiritual help needed and who can pray in his/her behalf. Those who unrepentantly engages in gross sin may be Disfellowshipped.

~~Jehovah's Witnesses believe all humans are born with inherited sin (Original sin) due to the transgressions of Adam and Eve.

SALVATION

Salvation is defined as deliverance from sin and death. Salvation is made possible by God through the ransom sacrifice of Jesus. Salvation cannot be earned, it comes through "the undeserved kindness of God" or "Grace", to those who have faith in Jesus and demonstrate that faith by works or acts of obedience to Jesus' commands.

~~Salvation can be lost by failing to keep exercising faith (by works or action) and falling into sin.

KINGDOM OF GOD

Kingdom of God (or God's Kingdom) is a government in heaven established in 1914 CE by God and ruled by His chosen king Jesus. Since then Jesus is ruling in heaven with co-rulers (kings), which will be a total of 144,000 (chosen Jehovah's witnesses called 'little flock' as co-rulers by God) altogether.

Immediately after becoming the King, Jesus waged a war against Satan and his wicked angels, the demons. Satan and his demons lost the war and were cast out of heaven to the earth. Now there is complete peace and harmony in heaven.

Satan is angry about being cast out of heaven and given just a short time to do his will, cause distress and chaos on earth. Eventually Satan will be able to convince all the kings of the world to get together and fight the great war (war of Armageddon) against God's Kingdom. God's Kingdom will defeat them and the earth will be turned into paradise for the faithful (called 'other sheep'). And God's Kingdom will be on heaven and earth forever.

Good news for mankind is, that there is very short time left for Satan, Jesus is ruling from heaven and his representatives the Jehovah's Witnesses are spreading the news of upcoming God's Kingdom on earth.

ESCHATOLOGY

Death: Jehovah's Witnesses believe at death a person ceases to exist, neither body nor soul survives death. They do not believe in possessing an immortal soul or spirit outside of the body.

~~At death; wicked individuals who knew about Jehovah and were unwilling to change, will face everlasting destruction (non existence forever) at death, never to be resurrected by God ; and the rest will be remembered by God and will be resurrected later.

~~The 144,000 chosen (by God) Jehovah's Witnesses called the "little flock" (who will live and rule with Jesus in Heaven) will be instantaneously resurrected to life in heaven after death.

Sheol or Hades: They translate and understand the Hebrew word "Sheol" and the matching Greek word "Hades", as to be and refer to the figurative location, the common grave of dead (in sleep without existence) mankind who (righteous and unrighteous) are worthy of resurrection.

Hell: Jehovah's witnesses do not believe in the existence of hell, traditionally portrayed as a place where a sinner suffers an eternity of fiery torment and punishment. Since they believe at death one cease to exist there is no point for existence of hell. They also argue that it is against God's nature to torture humans for eternity and hellfire is contrary to the Bible's teaching that "God is love".

The battle of Armageddon: This is the final war between human governments and God. Towards the end of Satan's given short period of time, he will be able to unite all the kings of the earth to fight against God. Jesus will lead the heavenly (God's) army to victory. At the end of the war, the wicked will be destroyed; Satan and demons will be imprisoned in an abyss (very deep grave prison) for a thousand years; and the righteous servants of God will survive. After the battle God's Kingdom will include both heaven and the earth.

Resurrection and Judgment Day: After the battle of Armageddon the Judgment day, thousand-year period will begin. During that time, the 144,000 heavenly joint heirs (the chosen ones for heaven, resurrected during earlier resurrection) will be judges and will rule as kings with Jesus for 1,000 years. Both the living (those survived the battle) and dead (worthy of resurrection) will be judged.

~~The righteous dead, the vast majority of Jehovah's Witnesses who were not chosen for heaven; and the unrighteous dead that include the unrighteous Jehovah's Witnesses and people that didn't hear or knew about Jehovah; will be resurrected (called later resurrection) gradually and judged.

~~Those resurrected to heaven will receive a spirit body and those resurrected to life on earth (earthly paradise) will receive a healthy and perfect physical body.

~~People will be judged before God by His chosen agent Jesus. People will not be judged based on their past but based on their action during that period. During this period some people will have their first opportunity to learn about Jehovah's will and to conform to it. All of those who do not conform to Jehovah's will, be put to death permanently during Judgment Day.

~~By the end of Judgment Day surviving humans will be restored to their original perfect state, as

perfect humans. Towards the end of Judgment day, Satan will be released from his imprisonment and allowed to try to mislead mankind one last time (the final test). Those who resist him will possess the earth, and they will live forever on it.

Earthly Paradise: God made the earth never to be destroyed. Originally only a part of earth (Garden of Eden) was paradise, where Adam and Eve initially lived. But after their disobedience God put them out of the Garden and the paradise was lost. After the battle Of Armageddon during the 1000 year rule of Jesus the paradise will be restored on the entire earth. People who will pass the final test of Judgment Day will live forever in the earthly paradise.

Heaven: Heaven (also known as paradise not to be confused with earthly paradise) is where God (Jehovah), Jesus Christ, and the faithful angels reside in the spirit realm. Eventually, before the battle of Armageddon a total of 144,000 people will be resurrected to life (spirit body) in heaven to rule with Jesus in God's Kingdom.

KEEP SEPARATE FROM THE WORLD

Jehovah's Witnesses are taught to maintain a degree of separation from the world, as most of mankind are alienated from God, ruled by Satan, and enslaved to the selfish, prideful spirit that comes from Satan. So, they are instructed to minimize social contact and interaction with non-Witnesses to maintain their own standards of morality.

~~Jehovah's Witnesses recognize all current secular governments to be flawed, and their only alliance belong to God's kingdom, an actual government in heaven, lead (since 1914 CE) by Jesus Christ as king. They respect the government where they live and obey its laws as long as those do not contradict or ask to disobey God's laws. They also do not celebrate national and secular holidays.

~~They remain politically neutral for religious reasons, and do not lobby, vote for political parties or candidates, run for government office and serve in the military.

STATUES AND IMAGES

Jehovah's Witnesses do not use statues and images and consider doing so idolatry.

SEXUAL MORALITY

Jehovah's Witnesses teaches that moral sexuality is between a man and a woman, within a valid marriage only.

~~Sexual immorality include adultery, fornication, homosexuality, incest, or any other unholy, unnatural, or impure sexual activity.

CONTRACEPTION

Jehovah's Witnesses let the decisions about birth control and the consequences of those decisions rest solely with each married couple. They prohibit elective abortion as a method of birth control.

ABORTION

They consider abortion as murder. Abortion is only acceptable at the time of delivery, when the parents must make a choice between the life of the mother and that of the child.

DIVORCE AND REMARRIAGE

Jehovah's Witnesses believe marriage to be a permanent union between a man and a woman (monogamy only) and must be legally registered following local government rules; and if local law allows solemnize the marriage in a kingdom hall by a Jehovah Witness minister. Marrying a non-Jehovah's Witness is strongly discouraged.

Divorce is discouraged and only allowed on the grounds of adultery. Remarriage is only allowed in the case of a death of a spouse or for divorced individual due to adultery.

FOR MORE INFORMATION (Some Sources Used For This Article)

<https://www.jw.org/en/jehovahs-witnesses/faq/>,
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